Since most of the world's life exists within such vaguely defined patches, theorists have attempted further clarification. Leibold and his colleagues have suggested two different ways of identifying metacommunities for study: distinct communities embedded within a "matrix" habitat, such as clearings in a forest rich in resources; and arbitrary sampling patches in a continuous habitat, such as a random circle of trees within a forest.

The work is still at an early stage. The world is undergoing a biodiversity crisis, and countless species and communities appear to be under threat from the effects of human activity. Metacommunity theory may, in time, help to provide a better understanding of how natural communities will respond, and how local changes to habitats may ripple through a region, either adversely or positively.